



a fancy of high-end performance laptops and premium ultraportable laptops. In a couple of years, SSDs available on a budget laptop, selling for ₹30,000 to ₹35,000 should become a tangible dream, going by the massive price drops in existing storage drives.

Screen

A laptop's display screen still remains a subjective preference. While a 13-inch laptop will suffice for a jet-setting execu-

tive, a 17-inch laptop screen is what an entertainment junkie desires from his desktop replacement notebook. Choosing between glossy or matte screen displays is still a matter of personal preference, but we think a glossy display is best for viewing movies and gaming, while a matte screen is more apt for reading text for extensive hours.

These days, it's difficult to get a laptop that has a 1280x800 pixel resolution – a norm on notebooks, created only a few

years back in 2008. Nowadays, a laptop, whether it's 13 inches or 15.6 inches wide comes with a standard 1366x768 pixel resolution widescreen display and a 16:9 aspect ratio – best for fitting in HD videos, whether they're beamed at 720p or 1080p. So if you're out to buy a budget laptop, you'll be hard pressed to find one which doesn't have a 1366x768 pixel resolution screen – whatever be it's size. However, the choices are a bit wider for someone with more cash to spend on an all-purpose home laptop for entertainment or multimedia use. Some laptop vendors are known to cram in a higher-resolution display in a small screen size – for example, a full-HD 1920x1080 pixel resolution screen in a 15.6-inch frame size. While there are popular intermediary screen resolutions on offer – 1440x900, 1600x900 and so on – you should choose the best bet within your budget. And remember – don't try to get a 1080p resolution screen in a small frame (15-inch), as it can be difficult to read text on native resolution.

Most laptops, in all price brackets, come equipped with a TN panel screen

HOW YOU TEST (LIKE DIGIT AT THE TEST CENTRE)

After buying a laptop and having gone through our retail store test parameters, here's how you can benchmark your laptop when it arrives at your doorstep in pristine condition. Why should you benchmark? Because this is when your laptop's going to be in its best shape ever. Therefore, it's important to catalogue its health and check how much it has faltered periodically (every six months or so). All of these benchmarks and tools are used by us while testing laptops.

- **Futuremark benchmarks:** To strenuously test every aspect of any laptop's core components – which is mainly the CPU, GPU, RAM and hard drive, we run Futuremark's PCMark and 3DMark benchmarks on all our laptops. The Futuremark tests are among the most widely recognised industry standard when it comes to ranking and rating a laptop's performance. Its fully licensed version doesn't come for cheap, but if you want to peg your laptop against others in the world and see where it ranks, this is one of the best benchmarking software you could try out.
- **Spyder Studio 4:** For testing a laptop's screen, we use Datacolor's 'Spyder Studio 4', which comes with a color meter that accurately tests the screen's brightness, contrast ratio, uniformity of brightness and color gamut (among other things). The device sells for ₹45,000 and while we know this isn't something that all of you can afford, it's still a great tool to have to precisely and accurately test your laptop screen's (or any screen's, for that matter) overall quality and health.

- **Battery test:** Our battery tests are conducted at high performance battery preset (from within Windows 8.1's control panel options), with screen brightness and volume set at maximum. For close to a year now, Digit has been using PCMark's internal battery benchmark for standard scores across the board and ease of comparison for posterity, but you can also take a look at Peacekeeper's battery test (it's a browser-based benchmark developed by Futuremark – <http://peacekeeper.futuremark.com>), or BAPCO's 'MobileMark', which is also one of the most widely used and respected battery benchmarks within the industry.
- **GPU benchmarks:** Testing out a laptop's graphics chip is extremely important, especially when a laptop comes with a discrete graphics unit (from NVIDIA or AMD). To thoroughly test out a laptop's GPU, we not only run 3DMark but also MAXON's CineBENCH 15 and benchmarks from games like *Sniper Elite* and others.
- **Diagnostic tools:** To ensure all your hardware is running properly, we have a few tools for your benefit. Check out AIDA64 (<http://www.aida64.com/>) which lets you prepare a detailed hardware report of your laptop's internal components for easy troubleshooting in future. We also recommend using tools like CPU-Z and GPU-Z for keeping tabs on your processor and GPU's vital signs. Also, go ahead and use Speccy (as mentioned earlier), as it comes with a nice little console for temperature mapping all your critical internal hardware.